

to below 270. The other ambitious option is to use their corporate connections to convince Shiv Sena to abstain or use the Sikh argument to get Akali Dal to stay away. All this, of course, is in the realm of desperate hopes.

Optimism is but the bridge between hope and fear, and fear is stalking the Congress. To start with, while SP General Secretary Amar Singh may have given the President a letter listing the names of 39 MPs, the fact is that six of the 39 are either rebellious, suspended, expelled or in jail. Of these, Munawwar Hasan has said: "I will not vote for the deal at any cost though I am an MP elected on an SP ticket." While another rebel MP Jai Prakash has dubbed the deal "anti-national" and vowed to never vote for it. On its part, SP has stated that rebellion has been quelled as MPs have been assured tickets. The moot point is that the same is on offer from BSP chief Mayawati and the perception is that the electability of the BSP ticket is seen to be better. It is an argument that SP will have to battle and make good on its promise.

Yes, there is the hope that JD(s) and RLD will back the deal eventually, but eventuality depends on what is on offer. Deve Gowda is looking for an omnibus alliance while Ajit Singh wants a slice of the action in Uttar Pradesh. However unless the Congress makes a quick review of its future alliances—be it Karnataka or Uttar Pradesh—these decisions cannot happen. Obviously, the arithmetic of politics is dictated by the politics of arithmetic. In each case, it is not so much the merit of the deal but the electoral merit of the alliance—that is, the potential of winnability in the next polls which will determine the



choice that parties make. The Congress though hopes to sell hope and use the fear of immediate polls to convince MPs and parties to toe their line. It knows that at the end of the day, it will have to sell several small deals to fortify the deal it made with SP to keep the big deal alive.

Indeed L.K. Advani has now repeatedly asked: "What is the 123 of the deal between Congress and SP? Why would two parties that till a few weeks back were abusive about each other be vowing loyalty at short notice?" On his part, Amar Singh has clarified that there is no "deal behind the deal", and that the SP support to UPA is issue-based and not in expectation of any ministerial berths. Which could be true. It wouldn't make sense for SP to acquire the anti-incumbency factor when polls are round the corner. Within the Congress though, there is distinct discomfiture over speculation about ministerial berths and over the Amar Singh missives to the prime minister. The SP spin maestro has dubbed Petroleum Minister Murli Deora as "a minister for private refineries" and suggest a windfall tax on private refiners. He has

also suggested the sacking of Finance Minister P. Chidambaram over his "mishandling of inflation" and mooted penalties be imposed on certain GSM operators who have been allocated extra spectrum.

It would be easy to dismiss these as a result of his proximity to Reliance ADAG chief Anil Ambani and sibling warfare between the Ambani brothers but Amar Singh has suggested that he "expected the prime minister to take his points as seriously as he has taken the N-Deal". Without doubt, SP will extract a price for its support as, after all, politics is not a one-way street. In a sense, the Congress has some experience with this. If the Left support came at the cost of freezing all reforms, other allies extracted their share of the perks of power. For all his integrity, the prime minister has had to silently suffer the existence of tainted ministers in his cabinet.

At a political level too, there is unease over the growing tendency to align with forces that have, in fact, eroded the Congress base. There is a debate within the party whether it is yielding too much ground and losing relevance in key states in its quest to forge new alliances. But the moot point is if the

**THE FIRST TRIAL** of strength for UPA will be to get a new speaker in place of Somnath Chatterjee, who is expected to resign.